

A FAITHFUL PATH COMMUNITY GUIDE

The Christian Spiritual Reset

*A 3-Day Guided Retreat to Overcome Burnout,
Hear God Clearly, and Renew Your Faith*

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FAITHFUL PATH COMMUNITY

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CHAPTER 2

Retreat Is Not Running Away

Somewhere between reading Chapter 1 and opening this one, a voice may have started arguing with you. It sounds reasonable. It says things like: *People are counting on you. You can rest when things settle down. Taking three days for yourself is selfish. Real faith pushes through.* If you are a parent, a caregiver, a leader, or simply the reliable one in your family, that voice may be very loud.

I want to answer it directly, because until you do, you will either not take this retreat at all, or you will take it while feeling guilty the whole time, and guilt will drown out anything God wants to say.

The accusation of selfishness

Let us name the fear plainly. Many sincere Christians believe that withdrawing to care for their own soul is a form of escape, and escape is a form of failure. We have absorbed a version of faith in which the most spiritual person is the one who never stops, never says no, and never admits to needing anything. Rest feels like a luxury for people whose lives are easier than ours.

The Bible does not support that picture. It gives us something more honest.

In **Genesis 2:2-3**, God himself rests on the seventh day, not because he is tired, but to establish a pattern for the people he made in his image. One of God's earliest lessons for Israel after bringing them out of Egypt was that they were permitted, and commanded, to stop. In **Exodus 16**, the rhythm of manna taught them that they did not need to gather every day; a double portion on the sixth day meant the seventh could be kept for rest. At Sinai, in **Exodus 20:8-11**, that pattern became part of the covenant commands, placed alongside the prohibitions on murder, theft, and adultery. Israel had come out of a land where they were slaves who could never stop working. In **Deuteronomy 5:15**, when the command is repeated, the reason given is exactly that: "You shall remember that you were a slave in the land of Egypt." A person who cannot stop is not free, no matter how productive they look.

Rest, in Scripture, is not merely a reward for finishing your work. It is also a declaration that God, not you, holds the world together.

Sabbath and retreat are not identical. Scripture commands a regular rhythm of rest, while a three-day retreat is one practical way of stepping more deliberately into that rhythm. This guide is not adding another command to your life. It is helping you respond to a biblical invitation to stop, listen, and remember that God remains God when you are not working.

Withdrawing in order to return

There is a second answer to the voice, and it comes from watching how Jesus lived.

Luke 5:15-16 describes a moment when Jesus' ministry was expanding rapidly. "Now even more the report about him went abroad, and great crowds gathered to hear him and to be healed

of their infirmities. But he would withdraw to desolate places and pray." Read that carefully. The demand was going up, and his response was to withdraw more, not less. The Greek verb is in a form that describes repeated, customary action. This was not a one-time crisis. It was his rhythm.

Jesus was not retreating because sin, unbelief, or spiritual burnout had overtaken him. His withdrawals reveal that communion with the Father was central to the rhythm of his earthly ministry. If anyone had a right to say "people are counting on me," it was Jesus. Sick people were waiting. Crowds had walked for days. He withdrew anyway, and he did not apologise for it. He returned to teach, heal, and serve, but his service was sustained by a rhythm that included withdrawing to pray.

That is the difference between running away and retreating. Running away has no intention of returning. A retreat is a withdrawal *in order to* return, with something restored that was missing. Jesus went to the desolate place and came back to the crowd. You are taking these days so you can go back to your family, your work, your church, as a person who has something to give again.

Consider the alternative. What are you actually offering the people who depend on you right now? If Chapter 1 described you, the honest answer is a distracted, depleted, slightly irritable version of yourself who is holding things together with willpower. The people who depend on you are already being affected by your exhaustion, even if neither you nor they have found words for it. Caring for your soul can help you return with greater patience, attention, and honesty.

Jonah and Elijah: two men in the wilderness

The Bible also shows us what real running away looks like, so we can tell the two apart.

In **Jonah 1:1-3**, God tells the prophet to go to Nineveh, and Jonah goes to the port of Joppa and boards a ship for Tarshish, in the opposite direction. The text says he went "away from the presence of the LORD." That is the mark of running: it moves away from God, away from what he has said, away from the people he has called you to. Jonah did not go to sea to hear God. He went so he would not have to.

Elijah, whom we met in Chapter 1, also left under pressure. **1 Kings 19:3** says plainly that he was afraid and ran for his life. Jonah and Elijah both fled, but their stories did not end in the same posture. Jonah fled in resistance to what God had said. Elijah fled in fear and exhaustion, yet in the wilderness he remained responsive to God's care and eventually received God's direction. Under the broom tree he prayed, even if the prayer was despair. When God fed him, he ate. Strengthened by the food God provided, he travelled to Horeb, the mountain of God. And when the still small voice asked, "What are you doing here, Elijah?" (1 Kings 19:9, 13), he answered honestly. His withdrawal, however it began, became a place where he could receive God's care, speak honestly, and hear God's direction.

The test is not whether you feel like fleeing. Many people who take this retreat will begin it feeling exactly like Elijah, and some will admit they are partly running from something. The test is whether you turn toward God once you get there. This guide is designed to help you do that. Every session will hand you a passage, a prayer, and a question that faces you toward him rather than away.

Retreat or avoidance?

Before calling your withdrawal a retreat, ask what you intend to do with the silence. Are you creating space to face God honestly, or are you using spiritual language to avoid a person, a responsibility, a decision, or a conflict? A genuine retreat may temporarily remove you from a difficult situation, but it eventually helps you return to it with greater truth and courage. If you finish the retreat determined never to face what drove you there, you may have rested, but you have not yet returned.

Three lies that keep people from resting

Over many years of pastoral ministry, I have heard three sentences over and over from people who needed a retreat and would not take one. You may recognise your own voice in them.

"If I stop, everything will fall apart." For some people, stopping requires careful preparation. Children still need care. Medication must still be given. A vulnerable relative may need supervision. Essential responsibilities should not be abandoned in the name of retreat. But preparation is different from postponement. Ask what can be delegated, simplified, rescheduled, or temporarily released. Underneath the sentence, for most of us, is a belief that we are the ones holding everything up, and that belief is both exhausting and untrue. **Psalms 127:1-2** says it directly: "Unless the LORD builds the house, those who build it labor in vain... It is in vain that you rise up early and go late to rest, eating the bread of anxious toil; for he gives to his beloved sleep." The psalm is associated with Solomon, the king responsible for building the temple, a man with more genuine responsibility than any of us. Even he was told that anxious overwork was vanity.

"Other people have it harder, so I have no right to be tired." Comparison does not restore anyone. There is always someone carrying more, and their burden does not make yours lighter.

Jesus did not say, "Come to me, all who labor more than average." He said, "all who labor and are heavy laden." The invitation is for anyone who is tired, without a qualifying exam.

"I will rest once this season is over." This is the most dangerous of the three, because the season rarely ends on its own. One deadline replaces another. The children grow, and the parents age. Ministry never runs out of need. If you continually wait for rest to become convenient, exhaustion may eventually begin making decisions for you, through your health, your relationships, your emotional reactions, or your spiritual life. Elijah did not choose to stop. He collapsed. It is better to choose.

Permission

Some readers do not need convincing. They need permission. So let me give it as plainly as a pastor can.

You are allowed to stop. Not because you have earned it, and not because you have nothing left to give, but because God commanded rest before you ever asked for it, and because the Son of God modelled withdrawal in the middle of the most important work ever done.

Taking these days does not have to mean abandoning your responsibilities. In many cases, preparing for a retreat is itself an act of responsibility, because it allows you to return with greater clarity and emotional presence. If you are married, explain to your spouse what you need and listen to any practical concerns. If others depend on you, arrange appropriate care before you leave. If three uninterrupted days are genuinely impossible, use one of the adapted formats in Part Four. The goal is not to prove your commitment by disappearing. The goal is to create honest, protected space with God.

Not everyone will immediately understand your decision. You do not need to defend your exhaustion, but you should communicate clearly, make responsible arrangements, and protect the time you have set aside.

Before you turn the page

1. Which of the three sentences above sounds most like you? Write it out in your own words.
2. Who would be affected by you taking three days away? Now write, honestly, how they are affected by the version of you that never stops.
3. Jonah fled in resistance to God. Elijah fled in fear, then turned toward God. If you are honest, which direction are you facing right now, and what would it take to turn?
4. What must be arranged, delegated, postponed, or explained so that you can enter this retreat responsibly and without unnecessary distraction? Whatever you wrote, bring it with you. The retreat has room for it.